

Pahankanuwa Sermon #5

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Sīladassanasampannaṃ,

dhammaṭṭhaṃ saccavedinaṃ;

Attano kamma kubbānaṃ,

taṃ jano kurute piyaṃ.

From:

Verse 217 from the Piyavagga (Chapter on Affection) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

Having a correct understanding of the true purpose and the true values of the Sambuddha Sāsana among both the laity and the clergy is a cause for the dispensation to endure for a long time. Therefore, the Buddha utilized various opportunities to highlight these objectives and values. He specially praised and showed special regard to disciples who practiced accordingly. Why? Because practice is the life of the dispensation. Where there is no practice, realization—which is the direct realization of the Paths and Fruits, the realization of Nibbāna, and putting an end to the *Dukkha* (Suffering) of *saṃsāra*—cannot be achieved. Therefore, the Buddha on many occasions extolled the value of establishing a mutual relationship between the laity and clergy in a way that fosters the growth of supramundane virtuous qualities.

The stanza we just recited, and its background story, is a good illustration of this.

One morning, when the Buddha was residing at the Veḷuvana Monastery, he entered the city of Rājagaha for alms, accompanied by five hundred monks, including the eighty chief disciples. That day was a festival day in Rājagaha. Perhaps it was a festival like the New Year festival we speak of today. Exactly at that time, a group of five hundred children was leaving the city carrying baskets of oil-cakes. When these children met the Buddha, they placed their baskets of oil-cakes to one side, paid homage to the Buddha and the Sangha, and then went on their way. After they had passed, the Buddha asked the monks:

"Monks, will you eat oil-cakes?"

"Where, Venerable Sir, are there oil-cakes?"

"Why, did you not see that group of children carrying baskets of oil-cakes passing by here?"

"Venerable Sir, to whom would children like that give oil-cakes?"

"Monks, do not say so. The reason why those children did not offer oil-cakes to me or to you is because the rightful owner of those oil-cakes is walking behind us." Saying so, the Buddha added, "Monks, we must eat these oil-cakes before we go." And the Buddha sat down under a nearby tree with his retinue.

Who was this monk who was the rightful owner of the oil-cakes? Walking separately behind this group of five hundred was the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa, who constantly received praise from the Buddha, who had even received the Buddha's own robes as an offering—having exchanged robes with him—and who had received the foremost position among those who observe the *dhutaṅgas* (ascetic practices) from the Buddha. He was the supreme monk in terms of ascetic virtue. Because this Venerable Sir preferred seclusion, in his usual manner, he was walking slowly behind, separated from the main group.

When the children carrying the baskets of oil-cakes saw this Venerable Sir, they developed a wonderful faith, clarity, and devotion. They bowed placing five points of their body on the ground, and offered the baskets of oil-cakes in their entirety to him, saying, "Please accept this, Venerable Sir." The Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa said to those children, "Children, our Teacher and the Sangha are seated there under that tree; go and if you wish to offer something to all of them, do so."

Having said this, the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa, together with the group of children, went to the tree where the Buddha was seated. Then, the children offered the oil-cakes to the entire retinue, with the Buddha at the head. They stood by, waiting until the monks finished eating, and then offered water.

After the offering of water was finished and the eating of the oil-cakes was over, a sort of whisper—a few critical words—was heard among the monks: "These children have behaved as if distributing alms by looking at faces. While the Buddha and the great elders like the chief disciples are present here, they offered all the oil-cakes to the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa who was walking behind."

Hearing this, the Buddha declared, "Monks, do not say so. My son Mahā Kāśyapa is dear to devas and humans. Therefore, devas and humans—not only humans but even devas—attend on Mahā Kāśyapa with alms and the four requisites. They make offerings to him." Having declared thus, the Buddha uttered the stanza we took as our theme:

> *Sīla dassana sampannam - dhammaṭṭham saccavedinam*

> *Attano kamma kubbānam - taṃ jano kurute piyam*

Let us look at its meaning.

"Sīla dassana sampannam": There is a fourfold virtue (*sīla*) belonging to the Sangha, known as the *Sīla* of Purification of the Four Requisites (*catupārisuddhi-sīla*). To mention them briefly, the first is the virtue of restraint according to the Pātimokkha (*pātimokkha-saṃvara-sīla*), which comprises the disciplinary rules laid down by the Buddha; training in this regard. That is one.

The second is the virtue of restraint of the sense faculties (*indriya-saṃvara-sīla*), which means restraining and guarding the senses such as the eye, ear, nose, etc., from defilements.

Thirdly, the purity of livelihood (*ājīva-pārisuddhi-sīla*), which means obtaining the four requisites righteously and properly, without resorting to improper means.

Fourthly, the virtue connected with the use of requisites (*paccayasannissita-sīla*), which means using the acquired requisites after reflecting on them with wisdom—reflecting on the true purpose of consuming the requisites—and utilizing them as an aid to meditation.

In this way, there is a fourfold virtue (*sīla*) for the Sangha. The Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa, supreme in ascetic virtue, was complete in all these four kinds of pure virtue (*sīla*). So, that is *sīla*.

Next, *‘‘dassana’’* means Right View. By virtue of the realization of the Paths and Fruits—since we are here speaking of an Arahant—he is endowed with that Right View. Thus, *‘‘sīla dassana sampannam’’*.

‘‘Dhammatṭham’’ means established in the Dhamma. He is properly established in the Dhamma. Through the direct realization of the supramundane Paths and Fruits, he stands firmly established in the Dhamma. *‘‘Dhammatṭham’’*.

Next, *‘‘saccavedinam’’* means he has correctly understood the Four Noble Truths.

Likewise, *‘‘attano kamma kubbānam’’* means, virtuous friends, 'one who does his own work.' Doing one's own work. Here, 'one's own work' refers to the work belonging to the Sangha as declared by the Buddha: the threefold training of Virtue (*sīla*), Concentration (*samādhi*), and Wisdom (*paññā*), which are aids to Nibbāna. It is the development of these. Thus, it means one who performs his own work, namely, virtue, concentration, and wisdom.

Therefore, the meaning of this stanza is: a monk who is endowed with virtue (*sīla*) and Right View, who is properly established in the Dhamma, who has understood the Four Noble Truths, and who does the work that belongs to him—*‘‘taṃ jano kurute piyaṃ’’*—such a monk is held dear by the people. That monk becomes popular. Thus the Buddha declared. Hearing this sermon delivered along with that stanza, all those five hundred children attained the fruit of Stream-entry (*Sotāpatti*). They reached the noble fruit of Stream-entry.

Thus, when we look at this stanza and the story, it seems like an oil-cake sermon fit for the New Year. But this is not merely an "oil-cake sermon." There is a very valuable fragrance of virtue and a taste of the Dhamma within it. Let us try to absorb it.

First, let us reflect on this. Here, the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa is a special person. He is someone special in this dispensation. Although there were chief disciples, their spiritual qualities were of a different order. Similarly, the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa becomes special because of those ascetic qualities—the *dhutaṅgas*—which assist virtue (*sīla*). There are thirteen such supreme practices that help one guard virtue (*sīla*) in the best possible way, and the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa was a monk who practiced all thirteen of them properly. He depended on alms, lived in the forest, wore rag-robles, was content with only three robes, and practiced many other such rigorous disciplines.

Also, it was because he loved seclusion that he walked separately from the crowd in that manner. On several occasions, the Buddha delivered special discourses to

the Sangha, holding him up as an exemplar. Highlighting the special characteristics of his lifestyle, the Buddha illustrated the conduct of the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa and his relationship with the laity through two beautiful similes.

Now, according to the stanza, the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa appears to be a very popular person. He was popular even among young children. We know that in this day and age, for a monk to be popular, he must be deeply involved with laypeople, associating closely with them and taking part in their affairs. However, the two similes given by the Buddha regarding the lifestyle of the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa help us understand something quite different.

What are the similes given?

The Buddha gave a simile about the moon, called **candūpamā** (the moon simile). He said that Mahā Kāśyapa moves among families like the moon. When going from house to house for alms, the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa is just like the moon. Why was the moon taken as a simile? **Nicca navakā - kulesu apragabbhā**—the moon is always new. The moon is renewed every day. Whether in the waning fortnight or the waxing fortnight, it is always something new.

In the same way, even though the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa went from house to house for alms, he was always a new person to those laypeople. How does he become new? Because he does not have excessive relationships with the laypeople. We know there is a common saying in our villages about "the comb of the cock seen twice a day." Such a situation arises if one associates too closely. There was no such thing with the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa; he was like the moon.

Now, when we speak of the moon, it is seen in our well, in the pond, and everywhere. But no one can catch the moon. No one can grasp the moon. In the same way, no one could "catch" the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa, even though he visited lay households. Therefore, it is said, **kulesu apragabbhā**—he had no over-familiarity with those families. There were no improper relationships. Pointing out those two qualities through the simile of the moon, the Buddha on one occasion advised the Sangha to live taking the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa as their exemplar.

The Buddha also presented another simile: the **jarūdapāna** simile. That is, "an abandoned well."

The Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa was compared to someone looking down into an abandoned well. Just as when someone looks down into an abandoned well, they do so without any intention of falling into it, but with body and mind withdrawn, so does he walk for alms among the laity, keeping his body and mind detached. Thus the Buddha praised the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa.

From these two similes, it is clear that the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa does not fit the word "popular" in the way we think of it today. He could not be a popular person in that sense. However, virtuous friends, there are two levels of popularity. There is popularity due to wealth, title, power, and so on. That is a very superficial popularity; it vanishes very quickly. Popularity born of virtuous conduct is something much deeper.

Here we see that when we speak of young children, we know that children can sense certain things almost by instinct. Compared to the minds of adults, which are mixed and confused with various thoughts and criticisms, children possess a purer mind. They can sometimes sense this abundance of spiritual qualities by instinct. This must be why those five hundred children, while not lacking in respect—as they did pay homage to the Buddha and the rest—were particularly captivated by the ascetic virtue of the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa who was walking alone. Being captivated, they offered the baskets of oil-cakes in that manner.

From this, it appears that those children must have had some innate meritorious potential. There is a saying, "The growing tree is known by its leaves." Likewise, within these children, there was a certain strength of virtue like a growing tree. It is for this very reason that upon hearing the Dhamma, they so quickly attained that noble state, the fruit of Stream-entry.

The Buddha has declared that even the state of Stream-entry—the first path and fruit—is superior to universal kingship. Why? Because there are only seven more lifetimes to be spent in *samsāra*, and one is forever freed from the four states of misery. They achieved such a state.

We can also understand how the minds of those children were prepared in that instance. First, they gladdened their minds based on the spiritual qualities of the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa. They recognized those spiritual qualities through the short stanza uttered by the Buddha. What we analyzed first was the meaning of that stanza. Through it, they understood: "Our minds were pleased because the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa possesses these spiritual qualities." If one rejoices in something with sympathetic joy, one simultaneously grows in that very virtue.

Furthermore, the pleased minds of those children became even purer. Next, we can understand that their generous giving helped to purify their already pure minds even further. Here, it was not only the oil-cakes that were surrendered. The mental impulse bound up with the oil-cakes was also surrendered. These children had set out with the intention of going to the park, eating these oil-cakes, and playing. Yet, all five hundred of them, with one mind, offered all those oil-cakes to the Sangha headed by the Buddha. Through that, their giving was complete. Their minds became exceedingly clear and bright. It was indeed with such a bright mind that they subsequently attained the state of Stream-entry through the realization of the Path and Fruit. Accordingly, we can see from this that there is a valuable taste of Dhamma and a fragrance of virtue within this.

Furthermore, if we reflect on this, the popularity of the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa, according to the facts declared by the Buddha, was a popularity among devas and humans born of his spiritual qualities. Now, there is a common concept—especially in this day and age—that members of the Sangha are those who depend on the four requisites provided by lay devotees. Therefore, they must repay a certain debt for this. This is an exchange; it is a transaction. This is also true. There is indeed a certain transaction here. It is just that the manner of repaying this debt is somewhat different. It is not like an ordinary worldly repayment of debt. This debt is repaid by producing a supramundane benefit in place of worldly things.

That is why the stanza used the phrase **“attano kamma kubbānam”**—“doing his own work.” For someone who does their own work, there is a word used in society: “selfish.” Thus, the Buddha describes the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa as one who seeks his own benefit. However, as this self-interest is being fulfilled—what is this self-interest? Fulfilling the Dhamma of virtue (**sīla**), concentration (**samādhi**), and wisdom (**paññā**) which are aids to Nibbāna—when these are completed, the welfare of others is already accomplished. Therefore, in that state, self-interest itself becomes the welfare of others.

Now, when we consider the four requisites offered by lay devotees to the Sangha, offering these is different from giving to the poor, travelers, and beggars. Giving to the poor, travelers, and beggars, virtuous friends, is done primarily out of compassion. Offering to the Sangha is done primarily out of faith. For this reason, the Buddha on many occasions, to remind the Sangha of the work that belongs to them, declared: “Monks, you consume the food given out of faith.” It is by consuming food given out of faith that you live. For that, you must repay the debt. You must repay the debt. How is the debt repaid? Four ways of utilizing the four requisites are shown in the Dhamma. What are those four?

The first one is:

Theyya-paribhoga (consumption as a theft) — if we use a common word, it is like "stealing" and eating. Consuming as a theft.

The second one is:

Iṇa-paribhoga (consumption as a debt) — like borrowing and using.

The third one is:

Dāyajja-paribhoga (consumption as an inheritance) — using something as an inheritance.

The fourth one is:

Sāmi-paribhoga (consumption as an owner) — using the requisites as the rightful owner.

These are the four concepts shown in the Dhamma. Let us analyze each of these in some detail.

Theyya-paribhoga (consumption as a theft) means consuming the four requisites without any spiritual qualities, without virtue (*sīla*) and other virtues. Through this, the consumer—the monk—becomes a debtor to the laypeople. No matter how much he tries to repay the debt on a worldly level, according to the Dhamma, he remains a debtor. He will have to repay that debt in *saṃsāra*, perhaps for a long time. Such is that situation. That is *theyya-paribhoga*—like "stealing" and eating.

Next, the second matter is *iṇa-paribhoga* (consumption as a debt). Using it as a loan. The second state is somewhat better than taking and using as a thief—borrowing. One cannot live without doing so. The four requisites are essential for the Sangha to survive. Some support is necessary for life: robes, alms-food, lodging, and medicinal requisites—something to wear, food to eat, a place to reside, and medicine. These are the four requisites. However, these members of the Sangha took these requisites as a debt.

Now, we know that if someone takes a debt—let us say they took a loan for a business or for farming—and if they squander it without any intention of ever repaying it, they are not actually a borrower, but a thief. Instead, if someone uses it properly and correctly to achieve that purpose, employing it in business or farming, and pays interest as occasion demands, then that person is a true debtor. He is someone who fulfills the duty of a debtor. In the same way, how has the Buddha explained this *iṇa-paribhoga*—"consuming by taking as a debt"? If

a monk uses each and every one of those four requisites—robes, alms-food, lodging, and medicinal requisites—by reflecting on them, considering them with wisdom, then it is just like consuming as a true debtor.

This reflection has two aspects. Now, let us say, to take an example, alms-food—food. Normally, lay devotees use food not only to appease hunger but also for the gratification of taste, to build up the body, and to make it beautiful. Since such purposes are not suitable for the Sangha, the Buddha has declared that one should contemplate the true purpose of the food—the alms-food—received. One aspect is considering the true meaning of food with wisdom: "I take this food only to maintain this body, to cross over this *saṃsāra*, and to lead this noble life of celibacy,"—this is considering the true meaning of the alms-food with wisdom.

Moreover, not only that, but the consumption of alms-food is also made into a form of meditation. How? "This food that I consume, called alms-food, is composed of the elements of earth, water, fire, and wind. My body is also composed of the very same elements. Although this alms-food was pure, when it enters this loathsome body, it becomes loathsome." What is achieved through this? Contemplation on the elements and contemplation on the foulness of the body. These two meditations are accomplished through it. That is it.

As we said earlier, when a loan is taken, the duties of a true debtor are to remember the purpose of taking the loan, to act accordingly, and to pay interest as occasion demands. Here too, the same is done. Regarding each of the four requisites—if it is food: "I took this as a debt. For what did I take it? To maintain this body in order to cross over the wilderness of *saṃsāra*." Thus, the purpose was considered. Next, what is the payment of interest? Turning to meditation. "This alms-food and this body of mine are made of the four elements: earth, water, fire, and wind." Right there, the truth of non-self is present within it—*Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self).

Furthermore, it is turned toward the aspect of foulness: "This pure food, entering my body, this filthy body, becomes soiled." Thereby, interest is paid. Why? Because this is a journey toward Nibbāna. Meditation is essential for the journey toward Nibbāna. Thus, meditation is performed through the consumption of the four requisites. That is the payment of interest.

Why did we describe this in such detail? Because some people do this in a different way. Some argue that simply by reflecting on the four requisites while consuming them, a monk is freed from debt. That cannot be said to be correct. There is a shortcoming in that view. A monk is not freed from debt merely by reflecting on the four requisites while consuming them. There is still work to be done further ahead. When the other points are explained, this will become clear.

That was the second matter we spoke of—*īṇa-paribhoga*. Next, what is the third matter? *Dāyajja-paribhoga* (consumption as an inheritance). Using it by considering it as an inheritance. This is explained as follows: Let us say a monk has attained the state of Stream-entry. From the moment of that attainment, that monk is a true son of the Buddha. Those who are in the three stages of Stream-enterer, Once-returner, and Non-returner are sons of the Buddha. But they have not yet finished their work. Such people are called "disciples in training." Those who are training in the proper manner in this dispensation. They have not finished their work. Such individuals consume these four requisites as an inheritance, just as children use their parents' possessions.

When parents are not at home, young children use their parents' things without fear, even though those things do not belong to them, simply because they belong to their parents. In the same way, the consumption of the four requisites by those members of the Sangha who have directly realized the initial Paths and Fruits—Stream-entry, Once-returning, and Non-returning—is compared to children consuming their parents' property. That is *dāyajja-paribhoga*. That is the third matter.

Finally, there is *sāmi-paribhoga* (consumption as an owner). Using the requisites as the rightful owners in every sense and meaning. This occurs after attaining Arahantship. At the moment of attaining Arahantship, the person who has attained Arahantship is described as one who is free from debt.

That is why—since we were speaking about the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa—the Great Arahant Mahā Kāśyapa attained Arahantship seven days after his ordination. He expressed this on one occasion: "For six days, I consumed alms-food as a debt; on the seventh day, I consumed it without debt." What did he mean by this? "Until six days had passed, I had not attained Arahantship. On the seventh day, I attained Arahantship." From this, it is clear that an Arahant consumes alms-food without debt. There is no debt to be repaid afresh. If they do any further work—if they show any special favor to the world—they do so out of compassion for the world. Out of compassion for the world.

That is why the Buddha waited until the first sixty attained Arahantship before sending them in various directions for the welfare of the many, for the happiness of the many, and not before. After they attained Arahantship, the Buddha did not say, "Go and repay your debts," but rather, "wander without debt in the world." It was not with the intention of "going and preaching Dhamma to repay debts" that he sent those sixty. We emphasize this particularly because some people interpret this incorrectly. When sending those sixty with the words, "for the welfare of the many, for the happiness of the many," the Buddha did not mean for them to go

and repay their debts. It is something done out of compassion for the world by those Arahants during the remainder of their lives.

Yet it is said there: "wander in the world free from debt." From then on, they wander without debt. Such a state of debtlessness is indeed true freedom from the bond of debt. From then on, *sāmi-paribhoga* exists. They consume the four requisites as the rightful owners. This is what shows how the debt is repaid.

Next, we know that because of the development of those spiritual qualities through the repayment of debt, Arahantship is described as a state of debtlessness. As a state of debtlessness. The Buddhas, the Arahants, and the Pacceka Buddhas consume the four requisites without debt. It is because of the supramundane value inherent in this transaction that you, virtuous friends, must often hear at alms-givings and other meritorious deeds that three factors must be fulfilled for an alms-giving offered by lay devotees to be of great fruit and great benefit. What are those three factors?

1. *Dāyaka-sampatti* (the excellence of the donor)
2. *Deyyadhamma-sampatti* (the excellence of the gift)
3. *Paṭigrāhaka-sampatti* (the excellence of the recipient)

Dāyaka-sampatti does not mean the wealth of the donor. It means the spiritual qualities that a true donor should possess. Being complete in a group of virtues: faith, the volition of giving, virtue (*sīla*), and so on. If one is complete in these, he is a true donor. That is *dāyaka-sampatti*.

Deyyadhamma-sampatti means the righteousness of the gift. Something earned righteously. Not something obtained through theft or violence. Likewise, preparing it well and offering it with care, not as something discarded. Offering in such a manner is *deyyadhamma-sampatti*.

Paṭigrāhaka-sampatti refers to the receiving side. When considering *paṭigrāhaka-sampatti*, in the highest sense, those worthy of receiving gifts are the Buddhas, Pacceka Buddhas, and Great Arahants. Or else, those who follow according to their spiritual qualities. That is *paṭigrāhaka-sampatti*. It is according to this that the gift becomes of great fruit and great benefit. This very matter is expressed in a stanza, often illustrated through the simile of farming:

> *Khattūpamā arahanto / dāyakā kassakūpamā / bījūpamaṃ deyyadhammaṃ /
etto nibbattate phalaṃ*

The Arahants are like fertile fields. **“Dāyakā kassakūpamā”**—donors endowed with all the virtues of a donor are like skilled farmers. **“Bijūpamaṃ deyyadhammaṃ”**—the gift offered is like good seed-paddy. **“Etto nibbattate phalaṃ”**—from this the true fruit is produced, becoming of great fruit and great benefit. It is in this way that a great mass of merit flows in. Thus it is explained.

Accordingly, we understand that the Buddha has shown us this proper, correct, and righteous relationship between the laity and the clergy through this story and the stanza, for the sake of future generations and the future progress of the dispensation.

In addition to this, let us reflect a little more. When we started telling this story, some might have wondered if this was a true event. There is a very deep matter here. Reading about the Buddha's life, one feels astonishment and wonder at the great wisdom and great compassion of the Buddha. The Buddha looks on with a correct understanding of the three periods of time—past, future, and present—just like watching a play unfold. He sees the minds of people in the world, what they do, and what they say. He sees all their past potential.

That is why the Buddha spoke in that manner: "Monks, would you like to eat oil-cakes?" and then, "Let us eat oil-cakes before we go." What was the Buddha doing here? Throughout the four incalculable aeons and a hundred thousand cosmic cycles during which he fulfilled the perfections, there is no oil-cake he has not eaten. It was not a strange thing to him. Nor did he have any special desire to make the Sangha eat oil-cakes. Rather, there is a very deep matter here. The Buddha created this opportunity for those five hundred children because he saw their supportive potential, saw the moment when their faith would arise, and saw that by acting on that faith, they would be able to realize the Paths and Fruits. It was to create this opportunity that the Buddha declared, "We shall go only after eating the oil-cakes." Here, we must contemplate the skillful means within that great compassion. It is truly wonderful.

At the same time, a noble quality of the Buddha, which we and the world can take as an exemplar, is his praising of the noble qualities of even his own disciples. In the case of anyone else, if they were offered an oil-cake that was not offered to me, their face would turn sour, perhaps looking like an oil-cake itself. Such things happen often in society, thinking: "An oil-cake that was not given to someone of my spiritual stature was given to my disciple." Instead, what did the Buddha do? "Monks, even though those children did not give oil-cakes to you or to me, the rightful owner of the oil-cake is coming behind us. Let us wait until then."

Thereby, the Buddha gives a great example to the world. He also used that opportunity to express the noble spiritual qualities of the Great Arahant Mahā

Kāśyapa through that stanza. Within this, there is also a message for the dispensation—a sāsana message—showing how the relationship between the laity and the clergy should be maintained.

Thus, we can harvest many such points from this story and the stanza. Within this "New Year oil-cake sermon"—as we mentioned earlier—there is a fragrance of virtue and a taste of the Dhamma. The more you think about it, the more you can absorb its taste. This is a good opportunity for that.

Also, you are now preparing for the New Year festival. Let us reflect on the Dhamma principles within it. What is this New Year festival? The wheel of time keeps turning and turning. It does not stop anywhere. It cannot be stopped. The wheel of time is just like a cogwheel. Along with it, our wheel of life also wears away, without our even knowing it—our age slips away. This cannot be stopped. We are only pushed forward; there is no time to stop and think. That is why certain customs have arisen. Many do not understand the deep meaning behind some of these New Year customs. They consider it only as a time for amusement.

Now, regarding this New Year, you know there is a period called "non-auspicious time." The non-auspicious time is a period that is not an auspicious hour. There is a belief among people in the world that everything—all worldly affairs—must be done at an auspicious hour. Therefore, when there is no auspicious hour to perform worldly affairs, that is the non-auspicious time. Some think, "We cannot just spend the non-auspicious time doing nothing, so let us perform meritorious deeds." That is a wrong view. This non-auspicious time has been designated as the "period for merit."

If we consider it deeply, it is indeed a "period for merit." How does it become a period for merit? We should make that non-auspicious time a pause in our lives. We should consider it as a small rest, a pause, in the midst of our activities. There is the old year, and there is the new year. In between the two, there is the non-auspicious time. We should make this a period for merit. Not by eating, drinking, and making merry. We should stop and reflect calmly: "In the past year, what were the wrongs committed by me—through body, mind, and speech? What were my shortcomings toward neighbors, relatives, friends, and the Triple Gem? What were my shortcomings in terms of virtuous qualities? What were my shortcomings regarding virtue (*sīla*)?" One reflects on these.

Now, you know that in households, for the New Year festival, they clean the houses well, remove rust, and tidy up; moreover, they even build a new hearth to begin the New Year. This becoming new—this should be made a renewal of the mind. An opportunity to renew the mind—washing away the refuse and rust in the mind, looking toward the future in accordance with the Dhamma, and

making this period a good period for merit to direct one's thoughts and actions toward Nibbāna so as not to fall into the states of misery in this perilous *saṃsāra*. That pause.

For such an occasion, we have presented some good, subtle aspirations in this Dhamma sermon. Accordingly, one can reflect: "Having understood this abundance of spiritual qualities, having correctly understood the values and purposes of the dispensation, how should we maintain the relationship between laity and clergy? What are the values of this dispensation? What is considered a 'transaction' in this dispensation? What has the Buddha shown us?" The non-auspicious time, the period for merit, is a good opportunity to reflect that we too must shape our lives accordingly.

Now, our life—the wheel of time may turn endlessly. It has no beginning and no end. Our wheel of life, caught in that cogwheel and wearing away, is not such a great thing. It is something that could cease at this very moment. Generally, no one can even state the lifespan of a human being today. Although we say it is a hundred years, it is much less than that now. In addition, due to various other disasters and dangers, both external and internal, we cannot say when our life will pass away or cease. Even while speaking like this, if the heart stops, that life is ended. There is such a perilous situation. Such is the brevity of life.

Next, one must reflect on the length of *saṃsāra*. For how long a time have we been born and reborn, dying and dying, suffering in this *saṃsāra*? Our true situation lies between these two. Having reflected on this, what has the Buddha declared to escape from this? Virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*), or the collection of virtues shown by the Buddha as giving, virtue (*sīla*), and meditation. There are many factors within them. Reflecting on each of them, we should make proper use of this non-auspicious time, the period for merit.

You know, in shops and businesses at the end of the year, they have "sales" to clear out old stock, selling them even at low prices to clear them out and bring in new things. In the same way, what we must do is clear out the pile of rubbish in our minds—even if we have to give them away to anyone who would take them—and renew our minds. That is what the New Year means. The New Year is not a renewal through clothes, cleaning houses, or paint. If it is a true New Year, it must be a New Year in which we grow in spiritual qualities. That is what a festival means—internally.

Now, thinking in that way, we must also consider the example of those young children in this story. Especially in this day and age, those young children give a good example to lay devotees. Why? Because on that day, those children went to

the park carrying baskets of oil-cakes, not with the intention of offering them to the Sangha, but to eat, drink, and make merry. Yet, they surrendered that. They surrendered that idea. Those oil-cakes, which are a very delicious food, they surrendered them all to the Sangha headed by the Buddha. Instead of the taste of those oil-cakes, those children received a supreme, supramundane taste right at that moment by attaining the fruit of Stream-entry.

In that way, we must reflect that the Buddha has introduced to us a set of noble values that are far superior to the values of this world. Living in accordance with those values and shaping our lives accordingly is what the Buddha Sāsana means. So, if we reflect according to the example given by these children, if we use the New Year merrymaking—though some level of amusement may be necessary—in a way that degenerates our future and ruins our lives, we will have to repay that debt. We will have to suffer for a long time in *saṃsāra*.

Therefore, if a festival is to truly gladden our minds, it must bring peace of mind. Everyone would agree that the highest happiness in the world is indeed peace. It is the path to that peace that the Buddha has introduced under the name of the peace of Nibbāna. That is it—that is the further shore.

To bring that peace close to our daily lives, some adjustment in our lifestyle, our schedule, and our daily routine may be necessary. If every virtuous person reflects in this manner, the next non-auspicious time will become a true auspicious time.

Indeed, we must reflect—some might think that if they do anything during the non-auspicious time, they will meet with misfortune. But, virtuous friends, "If one lives having obtained human birth without performing meritorious deeds, that is misfortune." It becomes fruitless. That is what misfortune means.

The true auspicious hour is indeed this period of a Buddha's appearance. Since we have received such a true auspicious hour, we must make use of this opportunity. Because we cannot do this every single day, wise people of old must have created a "non-auspicious time" at the turning of the year, designating it as the period for merit, and creating a brief pause to benefit from it.

But instead, what have the unwise done? They have added various other unnecessary things to that non-auspicious time, directing it only toward paths of amusement that cause their degeneration. Therefore, we must reflect in accordance with the Dhamma, making this period for merit a true period for merit, purifying our minds in the New Year, and resolving to spend the next year better in accordance with the Dhamma, reflecting on each and every one of our shortcomings in virtue (*sīla*) and correcting them.

In particular, the question of livelihood is a major problem for lay devotees in this day and age. The world is moving in a perilous manner in pursuit of material progress. This is an era that thinks only of the economy, disregarding righteousness. They do not realize this until they fall into the ultimate abyss. Therefore, for the sake of acquiring and earning wealth quickly, various livelihoods—wrong livelihoods—are coming to the forefront in this era. Wise Buddhist devotees must reflect on their livelihood, placing the Dhamma declared by the Buddha at the forefront.

Sometimes, there may be shortcomings and scarcities in daily life. One might not be able to become rich quickly. However, just as we have undertaken the precepts on this occasion, one must make a special effort to develop that noble virtue of abstaining from wrong livelihood.

Sometimes, one might think that what the Buddha points out are things that cannot be done in this day and age. Raising animals for meat, abstaining from the trade of flesh, the trade of weapons, the trade of poisons, the trade of intoxicants—to the extent that we might feel we have no job left if we abstain from such things. In this way, society is heading toward a perilous abyss.

But one must reflect: "Shall I continue to suffer in this long *saṃsāra*, or shall I make some sacrifice to escape from this, now that I have obtained such a rare opportunity of a human life?" Reflecting on this with wisdom, no matter what society says, and even regardless of how others in one's own home think, wish, or live—we are born alone and we die alone. Therefore, we must be responsible for our own *kamma*. The Buddha has declared:

> *Kammassakā māṇava sattā*

> *Kammadāyādā kammayoni*

> *Kammabandhū kammaṭṭisaraṇā*

> *Kammaṃ satte vibhajati*

> *Yadidaṃ hīnappaṇītātāya*

This *kamma* is our own. This *kamma* is our inheritance. It is because of *kamma* that we are born; *kamma* is the cause of our birth. Furthermore, *kamma* is our kinsman. *Kamma* is our refuge. Therefore, we must be responsible for the *kamma* we perform. For that reason, shaping our lifestyle is our duty.

Those shortcuts are often dangerous. Shortcuts, hastiness, are often dangerous. If one takes the unrighteous path to acquire and earn wealth quickly, or to quickly solve the problems of the household, that person will have to suffer for it someday.

Therefore, particularly at that time of taking account—taking the non-auspicious time as an occasion to take account—one must reflect on one's income during the past year. When we say income, if we look at it in a worldly sense, we can see a budget in figures. If we look at it in a deeper sense, what is this budget? The income side is merit. The expenditure side is demerit. What are the sins committed by us? What are the unwholesome deeds? What are the wholesome deeds, the merits, we should have done, could have done, and strove to do? Reflecting in that way is what is meant.

Now, in this manner, each person must perform a "transaction" regarding themselves. Now, a part of this New Year festival is to settle accounts with neighbors, remove ill-feelings, perform transactions, and thus begin a New Year. There is also a transaction that must be performed internally. We must not remain in debt to this life we have obtained, this rare human existence. How many die remaining in debt to the human existence they obtained? They were born as human beings, yet they live their lives and die just like human-ghosts or human-demons. One must make an effort to shape one's lifestyle so as not to fall into such a state; this is a good opportunity for that. Therefore, you must bring yourselves closer to the lifestyle suitable for this life.

In daily life, many people these days say—when speaking of a good life, it has become a sort of fashion to say—"We do not commit sins, we do not do wrong." It is something said very easily. But the work is not completed merely by saying "we do not do wrong." There is a positive side to this. One must perform wholesome deeds. Preparing the mind—ordinary practices, the practice of virtue (*sīla*). It is not merely a matter of observing these precepts. One must constantly reflect on them daily to see if one's lifestyle is maintained in accordance with virtue (*sīla*).

Furthermore, one must not stop there. The true purpose of virtue (*sīla*) in this dispensation is concentration (*samādhi*), meditation. If one does not build concentration (*samādhi*) upon virtue (*sīla*), it is of no avail. Then, virtue (*sīla*) is essential. Whether it is the five precepts, the eight precepts of pure livelihood, the ten precepts, or the eight precepts observed on Uposatha days—any precept is undertaken to restrain body and speech, and through that, to calm the mind and bring it to concentration (*samādhi*). Therefore, one must also be diligent in this concentration (*samādhi*). This calm.

This concentration (*samādhi*) also has two aspects, as tranquility (*samatha*) and insight (*vipassanā*). The mind is calmed on some wholesome object: loving-kindness, recollection of the Buddha, foulness, or recollection of death—practicing such a meditation subject in daily life during moments of leisure. Especially in the morning, before going to sleep at night, or when others are asleep, one should somehow find leisure and spend a short time—even five or ten minutes—developing a meditation subject like loving-kindness. By this, one's mind is purified as well as brought to concentration (*samādhi*). Through that, the mind is calmed.

Furthermore, one must not stop there. Those who developed only concentration (*samādhi*) and obtained high attainments and supernormal knowledges existed not only during the time of a Buddha's appearance but also during times when no Buddha appeared. Yet, they could not put an end to the *Dukkha* (Suffering) of *saṃsāra* merely by that.

Therefore, the Buddha points out that, established upon concentration (*samādhi*), one must next develop insight (*vipassanā*). It is for this that virtue (*sīla*) and concentration (*samādhi*) are developed. It is that wisdom-aspect of insight that is referred to as virtue (*sīla*), concentration (*samādhi*), and wisdom (*paññā*). An effort must be made to develop that as well.

One should not think: "How can we do these things while living in lay households?" In the past, during the Buddha's time and even in more recent times—as we just said, young children directly realized the fruit of Stream-entry. Within this, there is not only concentration (*samādhi*) but also insight knowledges. This is a very subtle thing. We must have developed meditation in various instances during our long journey in *saṃsāra*. Those are stored in our minds. They are stored in our **Viññāṇa (Consciousness)**. It is like a treasure of wealth. But we do not know this.

Even if there is a gold plate in our kitchens, we cannot recognize it. It is only when we scratch it even with a pin that we can recognize it. In the same way, within our mental continuum—after all, we have obtained a human life through some special meritorious power. Within it, there may lie those strengths of having practiced Dhamma and meditation in the past. They lie hidden. Whether they are laypeople or ordained—to bring those to the surface, one must begin insight meditation. Meeting suitable meditation teachers and with the help of noble friends, one must direct the mind to insight meditation in terms of *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self).

One must make everything encountered in daily life within this lifestyle a witness to this Dhamma, a lesson. Through them, one must practice seeing the Three

Characteristics declared by the Buddha. When the mind is habituated to this, at some moment, just like that, one can very instantly realize the Paths and Fruits.

There is a story from the past where a princess, seeing worms in the toilet she visited, developed the perception of foulness. She reflected on how worms appear in this body after death. That small thought assisted her even to attain Arahantship. In the same way, without letting our minds be disturbed or soiled by lust, hatred, and delusion by the things we see on the road, the news we read in newspapers, and the reports we hear, we must instead see within them the Three Characteristics of *Anicca* (Impermanent), *Dukkha* (Suffering), and *Anattā* (Not-self) declared by the Buddha. That unique view is indeed insight.

These days, some might say that whatever may have been the case in the past, or whatever the lifestyle of our ancient Sinhalese was, these things cannot be done today. In the past—as mentioned in our historical texts—our ancient mothers, even while pounding paddy, would not let the husk of a grain of paddy peel off in vain; they would elevate even that to meditation, reflecting on its impermanence.

In the same way, no matter what kind of luxury goods have been produced in the world today, you must see impermanence within them too. Is not what is in the living room today in the kitchen the next day? Is it not in the rubbish heap in the end? How everything—everything that is taken as modern, new, and beautiful—goes toward destruction, toward the mouth of destruction.

Next, how everyone—those who reign supreme with high offices and various fashions—meets their fate, destroyed in a single hour, in a single moment. Within these, one must see the Three Characteristics declared by the Buddha.

None of these are strange things. None of these are unusual. We commonly use the expression: "This is an accident"—that there is a category of things called accidents. But indeed, in nature, there are no accidents. Let us say a wheel of a traveling vehicle suddenly detached, or some such accident occurred. This did not happen only at that very moment. It was loosening slowly and slowly before it detached. Because we did not see it, we call it a sudden accident. In the same way, that is one side of our sudden accidents. The events that happen to us, the disasters we face—underneath them lies *kamma*. That wheel of *kamma*. None of them are sudden accidents.

The Buddhas and those with supernormal powers, seeing this, display a gentle smile. Why? "I saw this happening—it cannot be prevented, however." That is why they display a gentle smile. Just like a mother watching a young child trying to stand up. He must stand up somehow. Every time he falls, she smiles gently, does she not?

In the same way, when the Buddhas see human beings in this world distressed by being destroyed by these things called accidents, they think: "Alas, these people did not see this. The cause of this is some unwholesome deed committed aeons ago. It is its result they are experiencing now." Thus, such is the state of things in this world.

Indeed, in nature, there are no sudden accidents. They are natural events. To the word "natural", we must add—usually we call "natural" only those things that concern the inanimate, things without life—but the result of *kamma* is also included in this. *Kamma* is also a result. Just as we spoke of farming when talking about merit and demerit. Likewise, the Buddha has declared:

> *Yādisaṃ vapate bījaṃ tādisaṃ harate phalaṃ*

> *Kalyāṇakārī kalyāṇaṃ pāpakārī ca pāpakaṃ*

Whatever kind of seed one sows, that is the kind of harvest one reaps. The doer of good, the doer of wholesome deeds, reaps good results. The doer of evil reaps painful results.

Because of such a state of affairs, we must take the coming non-auspicious time as a true period for merit, conducting a special review, a reconsideration, a reflection on our lives, and based on the things we learn from it, we must resolve to begin the next New Year with a good lifestyle and a good schedule—on a valuable Uposatha day like today.

This New Year and the Uposatha day coming together should be considered as an opportunity to shape our righteous lives. You must reflect on the purity that has arisen in your minds through listening to the Dhamma for an hour today. Endowed with the eight precepts of pure livelihood or the higher Uposatha eight precepts, you have listened to the Dhamma, restraining body and speech, and generating good faith in the Triple Gem. It is based on a certain energy generated in accordance with that faith that you sat on the floor at this moment and listened to the Dhamma, directing your minds amidst various other obstacles and troubles.

The mindfulness applied in accordance with that effort, the mindfulness applied to listen to every word of this Dhamma sermon, and next, if any calm arose in the mind through this, directing the mind in terms of the recollection of the Dhamma—which can be considered as concentration—in this way, a basic exercise in developing the spiritual faculties and powers of Faith, Energy, Mindfulness, Concentration, and Wisdom, which are aids to Nibbāna, was

accomplished through this listening to the Dhamma. It is through this that you will be able to directly realize the Dhamma of Nibbāna on some day.

You must aspire: "May I have the strength and power to directly realize that noble Dhamma of Nibbāna without delay, in this very life, within this human existence obtained during this noble period of a Buddha's appearance!"

Likewise, if there is any mass of merit we have accumulated through this listening to the Dhamma and preaching of the Dhamma, may the devas and Brahmas who protect the dispensation—the divine and Brahma assembly—rejoice in it!

Continuing to provide protection to the dispensation and to us, may they realize the noble, supreme, deathless Nibbāna through their aspired Bodhi! Thus, we must share the merit with the devas.

Likewise, if there are any groups of beings, from the Avīci hell up to the Akaniṭṭha heaven, including our deceased relatives, who are expecting to rejoice in this merit of preaching and listening to the Dhamma, by rejoicing in this merit, may they be freed from states of suffering and reach states of happiness, obtain the association of noble friends, complete all wholesome qualities such as meditation, and be appeased by the noble, supreme, deathless Nibbāna! Thinking in this manner, transfer merit at this moment by reciting these stanzas:

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”